

The Battle of Gonzales

Decide whether a small skirmish over a cannon — the 'Come and Take It' fight of October 2, 1835 — was truly the turning point that began the Texas Revolution.

? Historical challenge

On October 2, 1835, Texian colonists at Gonzales refused to hand a small cannon back to Mexican soldiers and fired on them instead, under a homemade flag reading 'Come and Take It.' Almost no one was hurt — so why do historians call this the turning point that began the Texas Revolution? Map what led up to it and what changed afterward.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Gonzales, Battle of — Handbook of Texas Online (TSHA)

SECONDARY SOURCE

The Texas State Historical Association's entry on the opening battle of the Revolution.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What was the dispute really about?
- Why was it important even though few were hurt?

SOURCES 2

Gonzales 'Come and Take It' Cannon — Handbook of Texas Online (TSHA)

SECONDARY SOURCE

The story of the loaned cannon and the 'Come and Take It' flag made by the women of Gonzales.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did the colonists care so much about one small cannon?
- What did the flag's message mean?

SOURCES 3

First shots of the Texas Revolution fired in the Battle of Gonzales (HISTORY)

SECONDARY SOURCE

A short account of the skirmish and its minimal casualties.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How many people were hurt in the fight?
- How can an event be important without being big?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

BEFORE

Anglo colonists and Tejanos lived fairly autonomously in Mexican Texas under the 1824 federal constitution; Gonzales kept a small cannon, loaned in 1831, for defense against raids.



PRESSURES BUILDING

Santa Anna shifted Mexico toward centralism, dismantling the 1824 federal system and alarming Texans; Colonel Ugartechea demanded the loaned Gonzales cannon back, and the colonists refused.



TURNING POINT

Battle of Gonzales ('Come and Take It') · October 2, 1835

Texian militia crossed the Guadalupe River at dawn and fired on Lt. Castañeda's dragoons rather than surrender the cannon — the first shots of the Texas Revolution.



IMMEDIATE RESULTS

Castañeda withdrew toward San Antonio de B́exar empty-handed; 'Come and Take It' became a rallying cry; volunteers streamed to Gonzales.



LONGER-TERM CHANGE

The gathering force marched on B́exar (captured December 1835); delegates convened the Consultation, moving Texas toward the 1836 declaration of independence.

Who pushed toward this point?

Gonzales colonists and DeWitt-colony militia (the 'Old Eighteen' and John Henry Moore), determined to keep the cannon.

Who resisted?

Mexican centralist authorities — Colonel Ugartechea and Lt. Castañeda, ordered to recover the cannon.

Could events have gone differently?

Castañeda was ordered to avoid a fight; had he pressed the attack, or had colonists complied, revolution might have been delayed or sparked elsewhere.

Why could this be a turning point?

Why do historians call a small skirmish with almost no casualties the 'turning point' that began the Texas Revolution?
What changed after Gonzales that could not be undone?

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your before-and-after with a partner. Did you agree on what changed most?
- Which pressure do you think mattered most in pushing events toward a fight?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

The Battle of Gonzales (Oct. 2, 1835) was the first military engagement of the Texas Revolution. The dispute centered on a small bronze cannon loaned to the colony in 1831 on condition it be returned. When Mexican authorities demanded it back, colonists raised a 'Come and Take It' flag and fired. Casualties were minimal (about two Mexican soldiers), but the symbolic refusal set the Revolution in motion.

Common misconceptions

- The battle's importance is symbolic, not military — almost no one was hurt.
- 'Come and Take It' was a colonists' banner, not an official Texas flag at the time.
- The fight did not by itself win independence; it began a chain leading to San Jacinto (1836).

Vocabulary

Texas Revolution, centralism, Constitution of 1824, militia, dragoons, Consultation, San Antonio de Béxar.

Historical context

Cannon delivered to DeWitt's colony March 10, 1831; Col. Ugartechea demanded its return in 1835; Lt. Castañeda led ~100 dragoons; Texian militia under John Henry Moore fired Oct. 2, 1835; Castañeda withdrew to Béxar. Led to the siege of Béxar (Dec. 1835) and the 1836 independence movement.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was the Battle of Gonzales truly a turning point? Use evidence from at least two sources to argue what changed after it that could not be undone.